

BUDGET NDIO STORY

Follow the Budget. Find the Story.

budgetndiostory.org

PARTNERSHIP PROSPECTUS

BNS Foundation · BNS Studios

A Platform for Budget Literacy, Civic Accountability & Impact Storytelling

For Partnership, Programme & Collaboration Enquiries: info@budgetndiostory.org

WHO WE ARE

Budget Ndio Story (BNS) is a youth-centred civic platform dedicated to making Kenya's public budgets readable, relatable, and responsive to citizens, especially young people. We sit at the intersection of public finance, civic organising, and creative media.

Since its inception, BNS has engaged 50,000+ young Kenyans across all 47 counties through surveys, town halls, digital storytelling, and community dialogues. When citizens understand where public money goes and are given platforms to respond, governance improves.

Why this matters right now

Kenya's Constitution (2010) and the Public Finance Management Act (2015) both enshrine the right of citizens to participate in budgeting. Yet participation remains limited, especially for the youth, aged 18–35, who make up at least a third of Kenya's population but hold little de facto influence over public expenditure decisions.

The 2024 Finance Bill protests were a turning point as they demonstrated that young Kenyans are informed, engaged, and demanding transparency. BNS exists to channel that energy into structured, constructive civic accountability at every level of government, year-round, not just at crisis points.

Our Two-Entity Model

BNS operates through two complementary entities that reinforce each other:

BNS Foundation	BNS Studios
Civic mission — budget literacy, youth organising, scorecards, town halls, surveys	Impact content studio — producing podcasts, animations, research spotlights, and social campaigns for partners
Funded through grants, donations & programme partnerships	Funded through commissioned content mandates from development partners, the private sector, CSOs & government
Surplus from BNS Studios reinvested in civic mission	Minimum 40% of profits channelled back to BNS Foundation annually — sustaining the civic mission permanently.

This model means commissioning BNS Studios doesn't just get you great content, it directly cross-subsidises youth civic engagement across Kenya. A proposition no generic agency can offer.

THE PROBLEM WE SOLVE

For Government — MDAs & County Governments

Public participation is a constitutional obligation, but translating complex budget documents into formats that citizens can engage with remains a persistent gap. Most budget publications are inaccessible to ordinary Kenyans, particularly the youth. Ministries and county governments need credible, independent partners who can bridge the communication gap between fiscal policy and public understanding without compromising accuracy or institutional dignity.

For Development Partners, Foundations & Private Sector

Organisations investing in Kenya's governance, health, education, finance, technology, innovation, and economic development routinely produce high-quality technical reports that never reach the communities, stakeholders, and clients they are meant to benefit. Reporting requirements are met, but public understanding and, therefore, public demand remains low. As one practitioner put it, African organisations are doing remarkable work, but their results rarely travel beyond the impact report.

BNS Studios fills that gap: we translate institutional outputs into creative storytelling products, e.g., documentaries, podcasts, animations, and digital campaigns that real audiences actually engage with.

For CSOs & Accountability Organisations

Peer organisations working on governance, public finance, and civic rights often lack in-house production capacity to communicate their work effectively. BNS offers a mission-aligned partner, not a commercial vendor, that understands the civic context, maintains editorial independence, and produces content that serves advocacy goals.

For Young Kenyans

Budgets are not boring — they are the most direct expression of government priorities. BNS makes budget literacy accessible, engaging, and actionable for young Kenyans, equipping them to hold their representatives to account, participate meaningfully in national and county budget processes, and demand transparency in public spending.

WHAT WE OFFER PARTNERS

We offer concrete, valuable partnerships — tailored to what each partner needs.

01. Civic Programme Partnerships

Co-design and co-implement budget literacy programmes, youth town halls, scorecards, and public hearings. Ideal for: County Governments, National Government MDAs, bilateral funders, civic foundations. We achieve this through:

- Our three flagship programmes: **BNS Connect**, **BNS Mashinani**, **Wanahabari Lab** (for more info, visit www.budgetndiostory.org)
- Budget Town Halls — public dialogue events at ward, sub-county, and county level
- Youth Budget Scorecards — tracking commitments and expenditure against community priorities
- Community Budget Surveys — evidence generation on citizen priorities and perceptions
- Budget Explorer Content — free, publicly distributed translations of official budget documents and pressure points

02. Commissioned Content — BNS Studios

Your research, your institution, and your work. We make it land. BNS Studios produces commissioned content that translates complex institutional outputs into formats that real audiences engage with.

Format	What We Deliver	Starting Rate
Podcast & Audio	Research-informed episodes, expert interviews, public voice — distributed on Spotify, Apple Podcast, WhatsApp, YouTube, etc.	USD 3,500/ep
Short Animation / Explainer	60–90 second animated explainers translating one key finding or issue for social distribution	USD 2,000/video
Research Spotlight (Documentary)	8–10 min institutional video profiles featuring researchers, data, and BNS narrative	USD 8,000–15,000
Social Media Series	Multi-platform campaigns: threads, reels, carousels, quote cards over 4–6 weeks	USD 5,000–8,000
Town Hall Design & Facilitation	Full-service public dialogue: design, moderation, documentation, summary outputs	USD 4,000–7,000
Community Listening Sessions	Participatory sessions with consent management, documentation, and storytelling outputs	USD 2,500–4,500

03. Annual Retainer & Embedded Partnerships

For organisations with ongoing communications needs, BNS Studios offers annual content retainers and can be embedded as a 'Content & Engagement Studio' budget line in your grant applications, meaning BNS becomes part of your projects and initiatives from the design stage.

04. Training & Capacity Building

Short courses and workshops for government communications teams, CSO staff, and development partner communications officers on budget storytelling, civic media, and public engagement design. Through Wanahabari Lab we also support Kenyan journalists and digital storytellers to report accurately and effectively on Public Finance by offering them quarterly capacity building training.

OUR TRACK RECORD

BNS is not starting from scratch. We have an operational track record, active client relationships, and an institutional presence built over three years of civic work.

What	Details
Reach	50,000+ young Kenyans engaged across all 47 counties, expected to grow beyond 200K by the end of the year
Completed Work	Multiple paid commissions delivered to development and civic partners, including TISA Kenya, House of Fiscal Wisdom (HFW), Committee on Fiscal Studies (CFS)
Active Pipeline	Multiple mandates in negotiation, including major international NGOs
Technical Capacity	A solid team of experts ranging from Strategic Communication Expertise, Digital Storytelling, Civic Research, Finance and Budget, Economics, Public Relations, and Community Engagement
Civic Partnerships	Active frameworks with key ecosystem players and development entities, including TISA Kenya, House of Fiscal Wisdom (HFW), Committee on Fiscal Studies

African content studios with deep subject-matter expertise in public finance and civic accountability are rare. BNS brings that expertise alongside an existing youth audience and distribution infrastructure – a rare combination no generic creative agency can replicate.

WHY PARTNER WITH BNS

Africa's creator economy is valued at USD 5.1 billion in 2025 and growing at 28.7% annually. But most of that growth is in entertainment, not in the civic and development communications space that matters for accountability. BNS occupies a distinct position: a mission-anchored content platform with real civic roots and professional production capability.

For National Government Ministries & MDAs

- Fulfil public participation mandates under the PFM Act and Constitution 2010 Articles 10 & 232 through credible, independent facilitation.
- Reach youth audiences through channels and formats they actually use, not PDFs.
- Build a documented evidence base of citizen engagement that satisfies oversight and audit requirements.
- Commission budget communication materials that serve both public engagement and accountability goals

For County Governments

- Translate your Annual Development Plan and budget documents into an accessible public format.
- Design and facilitate participatory budget sessions aligned with OGP commitments and county engagement frameworks
- Capture and document community voice for integration into the planning process.
- Build a youth constituency for fiscal transparency, addressing the World Bank's Kenya Accountable Devolution Programme priorities, among other development obligations.

For Development Partners, Foundations & Private Sector

- Transform your research outputs and project reports into high-quality public-facing narratives, e.g., podcasts, animations, AR/VR outputs, and social campaigns that reach and move real audiences.
- Commission content from a mission-aligned Kenyan creative studio, not an external agency, thus directly supporting localisation and narrative ownership
- Satisfy ESG and 'double impact' criteria where your commission gets you high-impact creative content while at the same time advances development goals AND sustains Kenya's leading youth budget platform.
- Embed BNS Studios as a line item in your grant design, where we work alongside your programme team from inception.

For CSOs & Accountability Organisations

- Access quality production capacity without building an in-house studio, at mission-aligned rates
- Co-produce content on shared civic priorities: budget transparency, public participation, and devolution accountability
- Amplify your advocacy through a youth platform with existing distribution and community trust.
- Collaborate on national surveys, community listening, and public engagement design.

For Young Kenyans

- Join BNS Youth Budget Chapters and participate in real civic processes at the ward, sub-county, county, and national level.
- Develop skills in civic media, public finance literacy, and community organisation.
- Amplify your community's voice in budget and governance processes
- Be part of a growing movement that is making budgets the business of everyone

How to Partner with BNS

Programme Partner	Content Commission	Strategic Partnership
Co-design and co-fund a civic engagement programme such as budget town halls, youth chapters, scorecards, surveys, and other civic-level engagements.	Commission BNS Studios to produce impact content for your research, campaigns, products, or institution	Become a foundational partner of BNS Foundation, supporting the long-term civic mission with flexible, multi-year funding
Ideal: County Govts, MDAs, bilateral agencies, civic foundations	Ideal: Development partners, think tanks, research institutions, Private Companies, Individuals, UN agencies, embassies	Ideal: Foundations and partners committed to sustainable civic infrastructure in Kenya

HOW WE WORK

BNS is transparent by design. Our governance model ensures that commercial activity never compromises civic independence and that all partners, including government, development partners, the private sector, or civil society, can engage with confidence.

Non-partisan positioning: BNS maintains strict editorial independence. We do not endorse political parties or candidates. All civic content is evidence-based and governed by our Editorial Policy.

Conflict of interest management: Any transaction between BNS Foundation and BNS Studios is conducted at arm's length, documented, and approved by an independent governance adviser.

Transparency reporting: BNS Foundation publishes an Annual Impact Report. BNS Studios produces independently audited financial statements, with the Foundation contribution publicly reported each year.

Independent oversight: BNS Foundation's Board includes at least two independent non-executive directors beyond the founding team, providing external accountability for the mission.

Safeguarding: BNS operates under a full Safeguarding Policy, with particular attention to the protection of youth participants in all programmes and community engagement activities.

Client eligibility: Not every commission is accepted. All mandates are reviewed for alignment with BNS's non-partisan positioning and civic mission before engagement is confirmed.

OUR GOVERNANCE & ORGANISATIONAL STRUCTURE

Our organisational structure is aligned with international governance and organisational best practice.

Governance Level	Structure	Core Responsibilities
Board of Directors	Three Founding Directors	Serves as the highest governing authority of BNS, providing strategic direction, fiduciary oversight, financial stewardship, enterprise risk oversight, and accountability for organisational performance. Approves strategy, annual budgets, major partnerships, institutional policies, and safeguards BNS's mission, independence and long-term sustainability.
Advisory Board	Independent Advisors	Provides independent strategic, technical and sector expertise to strengthen governance, organisational effectiveness, innovation, partnerships and long-term growth. Offers objective counsel while remaining non-executive, with no fiduciary or operational responsibilities.
Executive Leadership Team (ELT)	Executive Director and Functional Leads	Provides executive leadership and day-to-day management of BNS. Leads strategy execution, programme and project delivery, research, media productions, business development, partnerships, finance, communications, operations, people management, resource mobilisation and organisational performance.
Staff, Consultants & Contractors	Multidisciplinary Team of Staff, Associate Experts, Consultants and Contractors	Delivers BNS's programmes, research, advisory services, strategic communications, creative productions and operational support through a flexible, multidisciplinary resourcing model that enables the organisation to deploy specialist expertise while maintaining high standards of quality, accountability and value for partners.
For more information on our governance and structure please visit www.budgetndiostory.org		

We are building a platform that earns the right to do its civic work permanently.

Get in touch:

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